



CUDDLES CHILDMINDERS & SCHOOLS (THE CUDDLES HALL)

SOCIAL MEDIA AND DIGITAL COMMUNICATIONS POLICY

Last Reviewed: August 2026

Policy Owner: Head of School / Public Image Officer

Applies To: Staff, Learners, Parents/Guardians, Volunteers, Contractors and Visitors

1. PURPOSE OF THIS POLICY

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) recognises that social media and digital communication platforms are valuable tools for education, communication, community engagement and the promotion of school activities.

The school may use social media and digital platforms to:

- communicate with current and prospective families;
- share educational information and resources;
- showcase learners' achievements and school activities;
- promote school programmes, events and initiatives;
- celebrate the achievements of learners and staff;
- communicate important school announcements; and
- build positive relationships with the wider school community.

These platforms may include, but are not limited to, **WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, X (formerly Twitter), YouTube, TikTok, the school website and other digital platforms approved by the school.**

This policy establishes the standards expected of everyone connected with Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) when using social media or digital communication platforms.

2. SCOPE OF THE POLICY

This policy applies to:

- all members of staff;
- learners;
- parents and guardians;
- volunteers and interns;
- contractors and service providers;
- visitors participating in school activities; and
- any person representing or communicating about Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) in an official capacity.

The policy applies to both **official school accounts and personal social media accounts** where the content relates to the school, its learners, families, staff or members of the school community.

3. GUIDING PRINCIPLES

All social media and digital communication connected to Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) should reflect the school's values of:

- **Faith**
- **Respect**
- **Professionalism**
- **Integrity**
- **Responsibility**
- **Safeguarding**
- **Privacy**
- **Courtesy**
- **Accountability**

Members of the school community are expected to exercise good judgement before posting, sharing, forwarding, commenting on or responding to content.

4. PRIVACY AND CONFIDENTIALITY

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) is committed to protecting the privacy and dignity of its learners, families and staff.

No member of the school community may publish, share, forward or distribute confidential or private information relating to another person without appropriate permission.

This includes, but is not limited to:

- home addresses;
- telephone numbers;
- private email addresses;
- medical or health information;
- academic records;
- examination results, where publication has not been authorised;
- behavioural or disciplinary information;
- personal family circumstances;
- private conversations;

- photographs or videos intended to remain private;
- passwords or login information;
- school security information; and
- any other information that a reasonable person would consider private or confidential.

School-related confidential information must not be shared on personal social media accounts, WhatsApp groups or other online platforms.

5. PHOTOGRAPHS, VIDEOS AND RECORDINGS OF LEARNERS

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) may photograph or record learners during authorised school activities for legitimate educational, communication, archival, promotional or celebratory purposes, subject to the school's consent arrangements.

Parents/guardians will be provided with an opportunity to indicate whether they consent to their child's image being used in school communications and publicity.

Where a parent/guardian has formally opted their child out of the school's authorised publicity and social media use, the school will take reasonable steps to ensure that the learner is not intentionally featured in such materials.

However, parents, learners and staff are also expected to respect the privacy of others.

Parents, Learners and Staff Must Not:

- photograph or record another learner without appropriate permission;
- post another learner's photograph or video online without consent;
- livestream school activities without authorisation;
- share images from private school groups outside those groups;
- photograph learners in sensitive situations;
- share images that could embarrass, humiliate or compromise another person; or
- use school photographs or videos for purposes unrelated to the school activity without permission.

The school reserves the right to require the removal of unauthorised photographs, videos or other digital content relating to the school community.

6. STAFF SOCIAL MEDIA EXPECTATIONS

Staff members are representatives of Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) and are expected to maintain professional standards both within and outside the school environment.

Staff must:

- maintain professional boundaries with learners;
- protect confidential information;
- communicate respectfully;
- avoid posting material that could bring the school into disrepute;

- comply with safeguarding requirements;
- obtain appropriate authorisation before posting school-related content;
- direct official enquiries to the appropriate school representative; and
- use good professional judgement when identifying themselves as employees of the school.

Staff Must Not:

- post photographs or videos of learners on personal social media accounts;
- communicate with learners through personal social media accounts where this creates inappropriate or unnecessary private contact;
- share confidential school information;
- post complaints, allegations or internal disputes concerning the school publicly;
- make statements that imply they are speaking officially for the school without authorisation;
- engage in online arguments with parents, learners or colleagues concerning school matters; or
- use social media in a manner that compromises professional boundaries or learner safeguarding.

If a staff member wishes to share photographs, videos or other content from a class, school event or school activity, the content must first be submitted to the **Public Image Officer or designated school administrator for review and approval.**

7. PERSONAL SOCIAL MEDIA ACCOUNTS OF STAFF

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) respects the right of staff members to maintain personal social media accounts.

However, staff should understand that their online conduct may affect the reputation and professional standing of the school.

Staff who identify themselves as employees of Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) are expected to exercise particular care when posting content publicly.

Nothing in this section prevents a staff member from expressing lawful personal views. However, staff must not:

- present personal opinions as official school positions;
- disclose confidential school information;
- identify or discuss individual learners or families inappropriately;
- publish information that could compromise learner safeguarding; or
- engage in conduct that seriously damages the school's reputation or undermines professional responsibilities.

8. PARENTS AND GUARDIANS

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) welcomes parents and guardians as important members of the school community.

Parents are encouraged to engage positively with the school online. However, all parents/guardians are expected to:

- communicate respectfully with staff and other parents;
- protect the privacy of learners and families;
- avoid posting complaints or accusations about individual learners, parents or staff on social media;
- raise concerns directly with the school through the appropriate communication channels;
- avoid sharing screenshots of private school communications without permission;
- obtain permission before photographing or recording other people's children;
- avoid sharing school-related information that has not been officially released; and
- respect the school's intellectual property, branding, photographs, documents and other materials.

Parent WhatsApp and Online Groups

Where Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) operates or participates in WhatsApp or other digital groups, these groups are intended primarily for appropriate school communication.

Parents should not use school-related groups to:

- insult, threaten, ridicule or harass another person;
- discuss individual learners publicly;
- circulate rumours or unverified information;
- advertise unrelated businesses or services without permission;
- distribute inappropriate, offensive or discriminatory content;
- engage in prolonged arguments; or
- share private information belonging to another family.

Concerns relating to a learner, staff member or school decision should be addressed privately through the appropriate school channel.

The school may moderate, restrict or remove participation in school-managed digital groups where a person's conduct breaches this policy.

9. LEARNER SOCIAL MEDIA EXPECTATIONS

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) encourages learners to develop responsible and safe digital citizenship.

Learners are expected to:

- treat others with respect online;
- protect their own personal information;
- respect the privacy of others;
- obtain permission before sharing photographs or videos of others;
- use appropriate language;
- avoid cyberbullying;

- report online harassment or inappropriate content to a trusted adult;
- respect the school's name, property and reputation; and
- follow school rules concerning the use of mobile phones and other electronic devices.

Learners must not use social media or digital platforms to:

- bully, threaten, intimidate or harass another person;
- spread rumours or deliberately false information;
- impersonate another learner, staff member or parent;
- share another person's private information;
- distribute inappropriate photographs, videos or recordings;
- create or share offensive content about the school community;
- encourage violence, discrimination or harmful behaviour; or
- deliberately damage the reputation of the school or another member of the school community.

Where online behaviour has a direct connection to the school community or substantially affects the safety, wellbeing or learning environment of learners, the school may take appropriate disciplinary action in accordance with its disciplinary procedures.

10. CYBERBULLYING

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) does not tolerate cyberbullying.

Cyberbullying includes, but is not limited to:

- repeated insulting or humiliating messages;
- threats made through digital platforms;
- spreading malicious rumours online;
- sharing embarrassing photographs or videos;
- deliberately excluding someone from online groups to cause harm;
- impersonation;
- publishing private information without permission; and
- encouraging others to target or harass an individual.

Any learner, parent or staff member who becomes aware of cyberbullying involving a member of the school community should report the matter to the school.

Reports will be handled sensitively and, where appropriate, investigated in accordance with the school's safeguarding and disciplinary procedures.

11. OFFICIAL SCHOOL SOCIAL MEDIA ACCOUNTS

Only persons formally authorised by Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) may create, operate or post on an official school social media account.

The **Public Image Officer**, or another person formally designated by the Head of School, will oversee official social media content.

Official school accounts must:

- present accurate information;
 - maintain a professional tone;
 - protect learner and family privacy;
 - use approved school branding;
 - comply with applicable consent requirements;
 - avoid discriminatory, defamatory or offensive content; and
 - reflect the values and ethos of Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall).
-

12. RESPONDING TO COMMENTS AND MESSAGES

Only authorised personnel may respond officially to comments, direct messages, complaints or enquiries made through the school's social media platforms.

Staff, parents and learners should not attempt to respond on behalf of the school.

Where an individual has a complaint or concern about Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall), they should be directed to the appropriate official communication channel.

The school may hide, remove or restrict comments that contain:

- abusive or threatening language;
- hate speech or discriminatory material;
- personal information;
- defamatory allegations;
- obscene or inappropriate content;
- spam or unauthorised advertising;
- threats to safety; or
- material that violates the rights or privacy of others.

13. NEGATIVE COMMENTS AND COMPLAINTS

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) recognises that parents, learners and members of the public may sometimes have concerns or disagreements with the school.

Complaints should be addressed through the school's established complaint and communication procedures rather than through public arguments on social media.

Staff members must not engage in online disputes with parents, learners or members of the public.

Where appropriate, the Public Image Officer or Head of School will determine the school's official response.

14. SOCIAL MEDIA DURING A CRISIS OR EMERGENCY

During an emergency, serious incident or crisis involving Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall), staff, parents and learners must not publish unverified information, rumours, photographs or personal statements that could compromise safety, privacy or the school's response.

Only the **Head of School or an authorised representative** may issue an official statement on behalf of Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall).

During a crisis, members of the school community should:

- rely on official school communication;
- avoid spreading unverified information;
- avoid posting photographs or videos of affected persons;
- protect the privacy of learners and families; and
- direct media enquiries to the authorised school representative.

15. USE OF SCHOOL NAME, LOGO AND MATERIALS

The name, logo, photographs, documents, publications, teaching materials and other intellectual property of Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) may not be used for commercial, promotional or other unauthorised purposes without permission.

Learners, parents and staff may not create social media accounts, pages, groups or websites that falsely represent themselves as official representatives of Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall).

16. DIGITAL COMMUNICATION WITH LEARNERS

All school-related digital communication with learners must be conducted through approved and appropriate channels.

Staff must maintain appropriate professional boundaries when communicating digitally with learners.

Where possible, communication involving learners should be transparent, school-related and capable of being appropriately monitored.

Staff should avoid unnecessary private conversations with learners through personal messaging platforms or personal social media accounts.

17. REPORTING A CONCERN

Any member of the Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) community who becomes aware of:

- cyberbullying;
- inappropriate contact with a learner;

- unauthorised use of a learner's photograph;
- disclosure of confidential information;
- threatening or abusive online behaviour;
- impersonation of the school;
- inappropriate school-related content; or
- any online activity that may place a learner at risk

should report the matter promptly to the **Head of School, designated safeguarding personnel or appropriate school administrator.**

Where there is an immediate threat to a person's safety, the matter should be treated as an emergency and reported through the appropriate emergency channels.

18. BREACHES OF THIS POLICY

Breaches of this policy will be taken seriously.

Depending on the nature and seriousness of the breach, Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) may take appropriate action, including:

For Learners

- counselling or guidance;
- parental notification;
- restriction of school privileges;
- restorative action;
- disciplinary measures; or
- other action in accordance with the school's disciplinary policy.

For Staff

- counselling or formal warning;
- investigation under the school's staff disciplinary procedures;
- restriction of access to school communication platforms;
- disciplinary action; or
- termination of employment where a serious breach warrants such action.

For Parents/Guardians and Other Members of the Community

The school may request the removal of inappropriate content, restrict access to school-managed communication platforms, or take other reasonable measures where conduct seriously breaches this policy or compromises the safety, privacy or wellbeing of the school community.

Where conduct may constitute a criminal offence or otherwise require external intervention, the school may refer the matter to the appropriate authorities.

19. RESPONSIBILITY FOR CONTENT

Individuals are responsible for the content they publish, share, forward or otherwise distribute online.

Deleting a post does not necessarily remove it from the internet, as screenshots, downloads and copies may already exist.

Members of the school community are therefore encouraged to **think before posting, sharing or forwarding any content.**

If you would not be comfortable saying it respectfully in person or seeing it published publicly, do not post it online.

20. POLICY REVIEW

This policy will be reviewed periodically by the school to ensure that it remains relevant to changes in technology, social media platforms, safeguarding expectations and school procedures.

Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall) reserves the right to amend this policy when necessary.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

By enrolling a learner at Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall), accepting employment or participating in the school community, individuals are expected to familiarise themselves with and comply with this Social Media and Digital Communications Policy.

The school expects all members of its community to contribute to a **safe, respectful, responsible and positive digital environment.**

Odomo Olubukola F. (Mrs.)
Head of School
Cuddles Childminders & Schools (The Cuddles Hall)